DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Where Does the Idea of Gilgul Come From?

Derech Hashem 2:3:10

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraph 10 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 7 June 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The last reason: gilgulim

After reviewing the explanations so far for why the righteous may suffer and the wicked prosper (cleansing, one's role, awakening, Hashem letting a person go down the path he chooses, continuing from one's parents, and the saddik who suffers for others), the Rabbi came to the last and final reason: gilgulim, reincarnation.

What paragraph 10 says

"Od shoresh aher nimsa lahanhagah..." There is one more root to how Hashem runs this world. In His wisdom He arranged things to increase the possibility for souls to be saved: a single soul can come into the world more than once, in different bodies, and in its second time it can repair what it spoiled in the first, or complete what it left incomplete.

The Rabbi drew out several points: - **Not only repairing sins.** A person may come back not because he did anything wrong, but because he did not fulfil his potential. Hashem gave him health and long life that should have gone into Torah, or wealth he did not use properly. He returns to complete his role. This ties back to the image of the servants around the king: if you were assigned to bring the tea and spent your time by the bins, you have not completed your task. - **No final verdict until the end.** The aim of the whole chapter is to form the kibbus hashelemim, the gathering of the perfect who will enter the World to Come. A person who is going through gilgulim does not receive his final verdict after the first life or the second, only when all of them are complete. Until then there is something like a summary judgement: "for the moment, you need to come down again because you haven't finished yet." Such a person does not go to Gan Eden or Gehinnom in between. - **Suffering from a previous life.** So a person in 2021 may suffer without having done anything wrong in this life, because he is repairing what he did in the 1800s. - **One's role depends on it too.** It is not only reward and punishment. The role a person is given in this world will depend on how he finished his previous life. - **Precise judgement.** For about the fourth time the Ramhal stresses that Hashem's judgement takes every variable into account. If in one life you had an angry temperament, that is factored into how you are judged for your anger. In the end, no one will be held to account for something that was not truly his.

You are not your body

To explain how this can be, the Rabbi returned to an analogy he has often used. An astronaut in space must wear a spacesuit, but after ten years he would not look in the mirror and think the suit is who he is. "We are not our bodies. Our bodies are simply spacesuits in order to exist in planet Earth." Who you are is your consciousness, your neshamah, your identity. In gilgul that consciousness simply receives a new spacesuit.

Who gets another chance?

A participant asked whether it is worth the risk of coming back, since one could end up worse. Another asked what happens if he repairs one fault in the second life but spoils something else. The Rabbi said he would return to these questions, noting that the Arizal has things to say about them.

He also pointed out that the Ramhal does not explain why some people get another chance and others do not. It is not a blanket rule that everyone who dies incomplete returns. Someone may simply have had his 120 years, with yissurim, Gehinnom and everything else already learned. He mentioned that Rabbi Nahman of Breslov is reported to have said it is your choice whether to come down again, and advised against it.

Is there a source for gilgul?

The Rabbi then stepped back and asked the group directly whether they believe in gilgul. One participant spoke of a feeling of having been here before; another said it is the only way to explain why people are born with knowledge. The Rabbi agreed that it is comforting: none of the other reasons explains children born with disabilities or intrinsic faults, and gilgul does so within a God of justice.

"But let's be honest here." Everything in Torah must be traced to its source: - **Tanakh** says nothing about it. That alone is not decisive, since tehiyat hametim is not stated explicitly either; but that is explicit in the Mishnah in Sanhedrin, and the Oral Law stands on the same footing as the Written Law. - **The Talmud** has no mention of gilgul anywhere that the participants or the Rabbi had seen. - **Rabbenu Saadiah Gaon**, the first to write a systematic work of Jewish theology (Emunot VeDeot, tenth century), reports that some people hold the soul returns in another body, and even more foolish people say it returns in an animal, and he rejects it as nonsense. - **The Rambam** does not mention it anywhere: not in the Guide, not in the Mishneh Torah, not in his commentary on the Mishnah. - **The Zohar**, which came to light through Rabbi Moshe de Leon at the end of the thirteenth century, is where it first appears. The Rabbi did not go into the history of the Zohar, but noted that great Hakhamim such as Rabbi Yaakov Emden raised serious questions about it. - **The Arizal**, in the sixteenth century, made it close to a doctrine, identifying who was a gilgul of whom. Returning in animals, he said, also comes from the Arizal; the old viddui texts for Yom Kippur, for example in the Spanish and Portuguese rite, contain nothing of it.

He told of Rabbi Shmuel Strashun, whose notes are printed at the back of the Talmud, commenting on the Gemara in Bava Mesia that explains "Barukh atah bevoekha uvarukh atah beseitekha": just as you entered the world without sin, may you leave without sin. He remarked

that this Gemara poses a difficulty for the doctrine of gilgul, since it implies that a person is born fresh. For questioning gilgul, the Rabbi said, some circles forbid learning his work.

Why the Ramhal includes it

Gilgul is not among the Rambam's principles of faith. The Ramhal, the Rabbi said, is like the Rambam in every way except that he also brings in Kabbalah, and since gilgul plays a large role in the Arizal's system, he could not leave it out. But he gives it only one paragraph: "Just the end of the page and that's it."

His conclusion: "Don't take this as gospel." A person may believe in it, but "it's perfectly rational for a fully God-fearing Jew to say, I reject this. There's no source for it." And gilgul raises more questions than it answers, which he set out for next class: - Who decides that some people come back and others do not? - If a soul lived in three bodies, what happens at tehiyat hametim? - Can a person come back and end up worse off?

Summary

- Paragraph 10 adds gilgul as the last reason the righteous may suffer: a soul may return to repair what it spoiled or complete what it left undone.
- Final judgement comes only after all of a soul's lives; until then there is only a provisional verdict.
- The body is a spacesuit; the person is the soul, which can be given a new one.
- The Rabbi traced the idea's history: absent from Tanakh, the Talmud, Rabbenu Saadiah Gaon (who rejected it) and the Rambam; it appears in the Zohar and was developed by the Arizal.
- He concluded that belief in gilgul is legitimate but not obligatory, and that it raises more questions than it answers.

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